Lesson 08: Reading a Tourism Website; Promotional Language

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 1: People and Places

Adapted from People and Places - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): 2.1: Reading a Tourism Website: Welcome to East County; 2.2: Writing: Promotional Language; 2.3: Randall's Listening Lab: The Four Seasons.

In this lesson

You will read "Welcome to East County", a tourism web page about the area east of San Diego, and find its audience and purpose. You will study adjectives, noun modifiers and four phrases that tourism writers use. Then you will listen to a student speech about the four seasons.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Find the title, audience and purpose of a web page.
- Put adjectives in the right place: determiner + adjective + noun.
- Recognize noun modifiers, such as "water sports".
- Write promotional sentences with "offers", "Spend an afternoon", "Don't miss" and "is famous for".
- Talk about the weather and activities in each season.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
tourism blurb	a short text that describes a place and makes people want to visit	"Welcome to East County"
promotional language	words that make a place sound good, so people visit or buy	Don't miss the weekly farmer's market.
noun modifier	a noun before another noun; it tells "what kind"	water sports, golf courses
majestic	big, beautiful and impressive	the majestic mountains
sparkling	shining with many small points of light	a sparkling lake
rolling (hills)	going gently up and down	some rolling hills
breezy	with a light, pleasant wind	The weather today is cool and breezy.
stroll	to walk slowly for pleasure	strolling along Lake Murray

Rules and explanations

Reading a web page

Ask three questions: What is the **title**? Who is the **audience**? What is the **purpose** (what does the writer want the reader to do)? The words, pictures and topics help you decide.

Adjective + noun

- An adjective describes a noun. In English it comes **before** the noun.
- Word order: DETERMINER (a, an, the, some…) + ADJECTIVE + NOUN: a sparkling lake, some rolling hills, the majestic mountains.
- In the book's example sentence ("San Diego's East County wilderness is one of the most diverse areas in the county featuring rolling hills, majestic mountains…"), the adjective + noun pairs are diverse areas, rolling hills, majestic mountains, sparkling lakes, deep canyons and desert landscapes.

Noun modifiers

- A noun can describe another noun. In "water sports", both words are nouns, but **water** tells us what kind of sports.
- The main noun is the **head noun** (sports). The first noun is the **noun modifier** (water).

Promotional language

- Tourism writers use many adjectives and some special phrases (see Practice 8). Two of these phrases are imperatives (Lesson 07): "Spend an afternoon…" and "Don't miss…".

Seasons and activities

- Pattern: In the [season], people like to [activity]. EX: In the summer, people like to go surfing in the Pacific Ocean.
- Many free-time activities use **go + -ing**: go hiking.

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - In Arabic, the adjective comes after the noun. In English, it comes before: sparkling lakes, not "lakes sparkling".
> - English adjectives never take a plural -s: majestic mountains, not "majestics mountains".

Practice

1. Before you read. Tell your tutor about a vacation trip you took or will take. What activities do you enjoy most on vacation?

2. Vocabulary preview. The book shows photos of these places and activities. Which words do you know? mountains, hills, lakes, wildflowers, canyon, desert, beach, golf course, art gallery, casino, restaurant, resort, rodeo; mountain biking, rock climbing, hiking, fishing, camping. Look up new words, or open the photo slides (see "Watch online").

3. Read "Welcome to East County" (see "Watch online") and answer:

- a) What is the title of the web page? Where did you find the title?
- b) What location is the web page describing?
- c) Who might like to read it (the audience)? Choose from the four answers in section 2.1.
- d) What is the purpose? What does the author want the reader to do? Choose from the four answers in section 2.1.
- e) What parts of the page tell you its purpose?

4. Noun modifiers. Find the head noun and the noun modifier: a) People use lakes for water sports. b) San Diego has many beautiful golf courses.

5. Two paragraphs. In your lesson material (section 2.1, "Meaning"), read the two paragraphs. Which is more interesting? Which makes you want to visit East County? Why? Write the words in the first paragraph that are missing in the second.

6. Why do we use adjectives? Choose all that apply: to add interesting details / to convince the reader that something is good or bad / to help the reader make a picture in their mind. What is the usual word order: (article) + adjective + noun, or (article) + noun + adjective?

7. Descriptive adjectives. Do the "Descriptive Adjectives" exercise in section 2.1: for each adjective (outdoor, luxurious, rugged, sharp, challenging, vast, diverse, natural, historic, annual, favorite, friendly), find the noun that follows it in the web page. Then match each phrase with its meaning in the second list.

8. Promotional language.

- a) Find these phrases in the web page and copy the rest of each sentence: The area offers… / Spend an afternoon… / Don't miss… / … is famous for…
- b) What grammatical structure follows each phrase? (The book's worksheet gives the first: The area offers + gerunds.)
- c) Write two sentences about each place in section 2.2 (Old Town, Ocean Beach, Little Italy), starting each with one of the four phrases. If you do not know these San Diego places, write about places in your own city.
- d) Are there any other phrases in the web page that you could use in your own tourist blurb?

9. Listening: The Four Seasons (see "Watch online").

- a) Which words do you know? cold, hot, humid, dry, windy, pleasant, cool, snowy, breezy. Explain three to your tutor.
- b) Listen and answer the questions on the website (it checks your answers).
- c) What are the four seasons?
- d) What outdoor activities do people like to do in your city in each season? Use "In the …, people like to …" and these words, plus three of your own: hike, stroll, fly kites, picnic, sledding, visit …, sunbathe, surf.
- e) Which of these can use "go + -ing"? Example: go hiking.

Speak with your tutor

- "You are a tourist. I work at the tourist office in my city. Ask me what to do here. I will use 'offers', 'Spend an afternoon', 'Don't miss' and 'is famous for'."
- "Ask me about the weather and activities in my city in each season. Correct my weather words and my 'go + -ing' phrases."
- "Give me plain sentences like 'The city has lakes.' I will add adjectives to make them promotional. Correct my word order."

Read aloud

1. ma·JES·tic
2. SPAR·kling
3. lux·U·ri·ous
4. RUG·ged
5. AN·nu·al
6. di·VERSE
7. CHAL·leng·ing
8. WIL·der·ness
9. Old Town offers shopping (↗), historical sites (↗), and great restaurants. (↘)
10. Don't miss the weekly farmer's market every Saturday. (↘)

Watch online

- "Welcome to East County" as the book used it (archived copy from 2020; the live page has changed): https://web.archive.org/web/20201216232735/https://www.sandiego.org/explore/inland-valley-mountain-desert/east-county.aspx
- Vocabulary preview photos (the book's slides): https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/1kznGWE3J71abhgpdUk9BfHMMcBQ091DiCEXo1mM7MDU/edit
- Promotional language worksheet (the book's link): https://docs.google.com/document/d/1kBHUQBR8wfEsEYL8UnwPtsOs-71RXoobbQrzAWnRy3Y/edit
- Randall's ESL Cyber Listening Lab, "The Four Seasons": https://www.esl-lab.com/academic-english/four-seasons/

Answer key

1. (example answer) Last summer I went to the sea with my family. I enjoy swimming and trying new food.
2. Check new words in a dictionary or ask your tutor.
3. a) "Welcome to East County", the big heading at the top of the page. b) San Diego's East County, in Southern California. c) Tourists who want to travel to Southern California. d) Convince the reader to visit East County on vacation. e) (example answer) The many attractive adjectives, the lists of fun activities, the imperatives ("Spend an afternoon...", "Don't miss..."), and the hotel booking box ("Find a place to stay").
4. a) water = noun modifier, sports = head noun; b) golf = noun modifier, courses = head noun (book).
5. Paragraph 1 is more interesting: its details and adjectives make you want to visit (example answer). Missing words: outdoor (adventures); boasts plenty of (instead of "has"); sizzling Las Vegas-style Native American (casinos); luxurious... tucked right into the rugged landscape (resorts); challenging... built around natural obstacles (golf courses); historic (sites); annual (festivals); expansive (landscape); California wilderness (country).
6. All three. Word order: (article) + adjective + noun.
7. outdoor adventures = fun activities outside; luxurious resorts = expensive and beautiful hotels; rugged landscape = an area in nature that is wild and difficult to walk in; sharp contrast = a big and clear difference; challenging golf courses = a place to play golf that is fun and difficult; vast (and beautiful) wilderness = a very big natural place; diverse areas = places that differ a lot from each other; natural obstacles = a thing in nature that blocks the way; historic mining town (also "historic sites") = a place with an interesting history; annual festivals = parties that happen every year; favorite day trip = a preferred journey for just a day; friendly town = a village where people smile and talk to each other.
8. Promotional language:
    - a) The area offers hiking, mountain biking, rock climbing, fishing and camping... / Spend an afternoon hiking Cowles Mountain, ... strolling along Lake Murray... / ...don't miss the spring wildflower bloom... / (Julian) this friendly, walk-back-in-time town is as famous for its apple pie as it is for its collection of gold mines.
    - b) The area offers + gerunds (-ing nouns) (book); Spend an afternoon + -ing phrases (hiking Cowles Mountain); Don't miss + a noun phrase (the spring wildflower bloom); ... is famous for + a noun phrase (its apple pie). "Famous for" can also take an -ing word: famous for surfing.
    - c) (example answer) Old Town is famous for its historical sites. Ocean Beach offers surfing and excellent cafes. Spend an afternoon shopping at the farmer's market in Little Italy.
    - d) (example answer) "In sharp contrast to...", "Get outside and discover your wild side", "A favorite day trip is to...", "... has a variety of restaurants".
9. a), b) Check on the website. c) Winter, spring, summer and fall (also called autumn). d) (example answer) In the spring, people like to fly kites. In the summer, people like to sunbathe and surf. In

the winter, people like to go sledding. e) go hiking, go surfing, go sledding, go sunbathing; also go picnicking (but "have a picnic" is more common). For "stroll", we usually say "go for a stroll". "Fly kites" and "visit" do not use this pattern.

My notes